

What Is Emotional Intelligence?

The term emotional intelligence comes from the work of researchers Peter Salovey and John D. Mayer (Daniel Goleman later popularized their work in his book, *Emotional Intelligence*)

“Emotional intelligence (EI) as involving both the capacity to reason about emotions and to use emotions to assist reasoning”.

Emotional intelligence includes

- abilities to identify emotions accurately in ourselves and in other people
- , understand emotions and emotional language,
- manage emotions in ourselves and in other people,
- use emotions to facilitate cognitive activities
- motivate adaptive behavior (Mayer & Salovey, 1997).

Characteristic:

Emotional intelligence (EI) is, in layman's terms, our level of ability to:

- Recognize and understand our emotions and reactions (**self-awareness**)
- Manage, control, and adapt our emotions, mood, reactions, and responses (**self-management**)
- Harness our emotions to motivate ourselves to take appropriate action, commit, follow-through, and work toward the achievement of our goals (**motivation**)
- Discern the feelings of others, understand their emotions, and utilize that understanding to relate to others more effectively (**empathy**)

- **Build relationships**, relate to others in social situations, lead, negotiate conflict, and work as part of a team (**social skills**)

The Four Branch Model of Emotional Intelligence:

The four-branch model of emotional intelligence describes four areas of capacities or skills that collectively describe many of areas of emotional intelligence (Mayer & Salovey, 1997). More specifically, this model defines emotional intelligence as involving the abilities to:

1. accurately **perceive emotions** in oneself and others
2. **use emotions to facilitate thinking**
3. **understand emotional meanings**, and
4. **manage emotions**

Perceive Emotions

“The **ability to accurately identify and express feelings**”.

Emotional perception involves registering, attending to, and deciphering emotional messages as they are expressed in facial expressions, voice tone, or cultural artifacts. **Individuals differ in their abilities to discern the emotional content of such stimuli.** These competencies are basic information processing skills in which the relevant information consists of feelings and mood states. For example, some individuals, called alexithymic, have difficulty expressing their emotions verbally, presumably because they have difficulty identifying those feelings (Apfel & Sifneos, 1979; Bagby, Parker, & Taylor, 1993a, 1993b).

Use emotions to facilitate thinking

“The **ability to use your feelings constructively**”

This second branch of emotional intelligence focuses on **how emotion affects the cognitive system** and, as such, can be harnessed for more effective problem solving, reasoning, decision making, and creative endeavors. Although cognition can be disrupted by emotions, such as anxiety and fear, emotions also can prioritize the cognitive system to attend to what is important (Easterbrook, 1959; Leeper, 1948; Mandler, 1975; Simon, 1982) and even to focus on what it does best in a given mood (e.g., Palfai & Salovey, 1993; Schwarz, 1990).

Emotional Understanding:

"The ability to understand the meanings of emotions and how they can change"

This includes the ability to understand...

- The **purpose of emotions**; understanding their survival value to the species
- The **relationships between emotions**; how and why they can change from one feeling to another
- The emotions which lead to the behavior in yourself and others
- The **relationship between thoughts and feelings**
- The **causes of emotions** and their relationship to our human psychological needs, especially our unmet emotional needs.

Emotional Management

"The ability to manage emotions for personal and social growth"

- The ability to take responsibility for one's own feelings and happiness
- **The ability to turn negative emotions into positive learning and growing opportunities**
- **The ability to help others identify and benefit from their emotions**

The Importance of Emotional Intelligence:

If you think emotional intelligence is only important for those who always have to interact or communicate with people, think it again. Emotional intelligence is a gateway to a balanced-life. It's essential to basically every aspect of life:

Physical Health:

The ability to take care of our bodies and specially to manage our stress, which has an incredible impact on our overall wellness, is heavily tied to our emotional intelligence. Only by being aware of our emotional state and our reactions to stress in our lives can we hope to manage stress and maintain good health.

Mental Well-Being:

Emotional intelligence affects our attitude and outlook on life. It can also help to alleviate anxiety and avoid depression and mood swings. A high level of emotional intelligence directly correlates to a positive attitude and happier outlook on life.

Relationships

By better understanding and managing our emotions, we are better able to communicate our feelings in a more constructive way. We are also better able to understand and relate to those with whom we are in relationships.

Understanding the needs, feelings, and responses of those we care about leads to stronger and more fulfilling relationships.

Conflict Resolution:

When we can discern people's emotions and empathize with their perspective, it's much easier to resolve conflicts or possibly avoid them before they start. We are also better at negotiation due to the very nature of our ability to understand the needs and desires of others. It's easier to give people what they want if we can perceive what it is.

Success:

Higher emotional intelligence helps us to be stronger internal motivators, which can **reduce procrastination**, **increase self-confidence**, and **improve our ability to focus on a goal**.

This guide will help you break your limits and overcome any challenges you have in order to live your best life. It also allows us to [create better networks](#) of support, overcome setbacks, and persevere with a more resilient outlook. **Our ability to delay gratification and see the long-term directly affects our ability to succeed.**

Leadership:



The ability to understand what motivates others, relate in a positive manner, and to build stronger bonds with others in the workplace inevitably **makes those with higher emotional intelligence better leaders.** **An effective leader can recognize what the needs of his people are**, so that those needs can be met in a way that encourages higher performance and [workplace satisfaction](#).

An emotionally savvy and intelligent leader is also able to build stronger teams by strategically utilizing the emotional diversity of their team members to benefit the team as a whole.

Emotional intelligence is still not completely understood, but what we do know is that emotions play a very critical role in the overall quality of our personal and professional lives, more critical even than our actual measure of brain intelligence.

While tools and technology can help us to learn and master information, nothing can replace our ability to learn, manage, and master our emotions and the emotions of those around us.

Emotional intelligence and positive outcomes

Emotional Intelligence (EQ) is the ability to identify, use, understand, and manage emotions in an effective and positive way.

- The high EI individual, most centrally, can better perceive emotions, use them in thought, understand their meanings, and manage emotions than others. Solving emotional problems likely requires less cognitive effort for this individual.
- The high EI person is drawn to occupations involving social interactions such as teaching and counseling more so than to occupations involving clerical or administrative tasks.
- The high EI individual, relative to others, is less apt to engage in problem behaviors and avoids self-destructive, negative behaviors such as smoking, excessive drinking, drug abuse, or violent episodes with others.
- The high EI person is more likely to have possessions of sentimental attachment around the home and to have more positive social interactions, particularly if the individual scored highly on emotional management. Such individuals may also be more adept at describing motivational goals, aims, and missions (Mayer, Salovey, & Caruso, 2004)
- A high EQ helps individuals to communicate better, reduce their anxiety and stress, defuse conflicts, improve relationships, empathize with others, and effectively overcome life's challenges.
- Our emotional intelligence affects the quality of our lives because it influences our behavior and relationships. EQ is synonymous

with self-awareness because it enables us to live our lives with intention, purpose, and autonomy.

Ways to cultivate and increase emotional intelligence

- **Self-awareness.**

This is the ability to label, recognize, and understand your own emotions. Self-awareness requires us to tune in to our feelings and not avoid our negative emotions such as anxiety, fear and sadness.

Recognizing our own emotional states and how they affect our thoughts, behaviors, and decisions is the key to cultivating self-awareness.

- **Emotional regulation.**

Emotional regulation has to do with our ability to control strong emotions by not acting on raw feelings in an impulsive or destructive manner. Developing the ability to sit with unpleasant feelings and to give ourselves the time and space to decide how we may alleviate or reduce negative feelings cultivates self-confidence. Emotional regulation also helps us develop the ability to consider various solutions to a particular situation or problem. Not reacting solely from an emotionally charged state results in better decision-making outcomes.

- **Empathy.**

When we empathize with others, we develop deeper, more intimate relationships. Empathy is the ability to recognize how and why people feel the way they do. Empathy allows us to anticipate how our actions and behaviors influence other people as well as our own. Developing

empathy skills enhances our experiences, relationships, and general understanding of ourselves, other people and the world around us.

- **Social skills.**

This is a very broad term. In general, having strong social skills means having the ability to communicate in a clear, concise, and courteous manner. In a nutshell, good social skills are the summation of all of the components of EI: self-awareness, emotional regulation, and empathy.

Can EI be taught?

Some people have EI as a natural talent, for those that don't, EI skills can be learned. There has been some clear and focused research that supports this fact. People can learn how to interact more effectively at work and increase their emotional intelligence. To make this happen, an individual needs to be personally motivated to do this. Individuals need to first have a handle of where they are starting from (assessment) and then understand which of the five components of EI need the greatest attention.

Each one of these five components has specific elements and action items that can help with an increase in these areas.

Self-Awareness – Take your emotional temperature on a regular basis and asking yourself, “what am I feeling right now?”

Self-Regulation – Creating a list of things that positively impact you to reduce any negative emotion you may be experiencing.

Motivation – Creating a “Vision Board” of those things that you find motivating and goals for which you are striving. Refer to this board often.

Empathy – Identifying a role model that you would describe as empathetic. What are the things that this person does that demonstrates empathy? Which of these qualities can you learn and demonstrate the same?

Social Skills – Creating a calendar for how / when you reach out to others to build stronger relationships.

